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Activity-based management of a community reading park for rural community empowerment in Gunungkidul, Indonesia

Tri Sudaryani[a,1*], S. Sujarwo[a,2]

[a] Department of Nonformal Education, Faculty of Education, Universitas Negeri Yogyakarta, Jl. Colombo No.1, Karang Malang, Caturtunggal, Kec. Depok, Kabupaten Sleman, Daerah Istimewa Yogyakarta 55281, Indonesia

[1]trisudaryani.2024@student.uny.ac.id; [2]sujarwo@uny.ac.id

***Corresponding author**

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ABSTRACT

Community reading parks (Taman Bacaan Masyarakat, TBM) can function as community learning spaces when they are managed beyond book-lending services and connected to local needs. This article transforms a qualitative thesis on TBM Gubug Pintar in Semanu, Gunungkidul, into a journal-style manuscript. The study aimed to analyze the activity-based management strategy of TBM Gubug Pintar, describe its empowerment outcomes, and identify supporting and inhibiting factors. A descriptive qualitative approach was used with TBM managers, volunteers, activity participants, community leaders, and local government representatives as information sources. Data were collected through in-depth interviews, participant observation, and documentation, and were validated using source and method triangulation. The findings show that TBM Gubug Pintar applies a participatory management cycle consisting of planning, organizing, actuating, and controlling. These functions are operationalized through basic literacy classes, Sinau Bareng, religious and character education, entrepreneurship training, digital literacy activities, local product development, environmental literacy, and arts and cultural preservation. The strategy contributes to improved literacy practices, stronger family economic creativity, cultural continuity, and social solidarity. The main supporting factors are volunteer commitment, community participation, government support, and multisector partnerships, whereas the main constraints are limited facilities, operational funding, digital infrastructure, and volunteer regeneration. The article argues that activity-based TBM management is a promising model for integrating literacy, skills development, and rural community empowerment.

Kata kunci
Kegiatan literasi
Manajemen partisipatif
Pemberdayaan masyarakat
Pendidikan nonformal
Taman bacaan masyarakat

Manajemen berbasis aktivitas pada taman bacaan masyarakat untuk pemberdayaan masyarakat pedesaan di Gunungkidul, Indonesia. Taman Bacaan Masyarakat (TBM) dapat berfungsi sebagai ruang belajar masyarakat apabila dikelola tidak hanya sebatas layanan peminjaman buku, tetapi juga dihubungkan dengan kebutuhan lokal. Artikel ini mentransformasikan tesis kualitatif tentang TBM Gubug Pintar di Semanu, Gunungkidul, ke dalam bentuk naskah bergaya jurnal. Penelitian ini bertujuan untuk menganalisis strategi manajemen berbasis aktivitas di TBM Gubug Pintar, mendeskripsikan hasil pemberdayaannya, serta mengidentifikasi faktor pendukung dan penghambatnya. Penelitian ini menggunakan pendekatan deskriptif kualitatif dengan pengelola TBM, relawan, peserta kegiatan, tokoh masyarakat, dan perwakilan pemerintah daerah sebagai sumber informasi. Data dikumpulkan melalui wawancara mendalam, observasi partisipatif, dan dokumentasi, serta divalidasi menggunakan triangulasi sumber dan metode. Hasil penelitian menunjukkan bahwa TBM Gubug Pintar menerapkan siklus manajemen partisipatif yang terdiri atas perencanaan, pengorganisasian, pelaksanaan, dan pengendalian. Fungsi-fungsi tersebut dioperasionalkan melalui kelas literasi dasar, Sinau Bareng, pendidikan agama dan karakter, pelatihan kewirausahaan, kegiatan literasi digital, pengembangan produk lokal, literasi lingkungan, serta pelestarian seni dan budaya. Strategi tersebut berkontribusi terhadap peningkatan praktik literasi, penguatan kreativitas ekonomi keluarga, keberlanjutan budaya, dan solidaritas sosial. Faktor pendukung utama meliputi komitmen relawan, partisipasi masyarakat, dukungan pemerintah, dan kemitraan multisektor, sedangkan kendala utama mencakup keterbatasan fasilitas, pendanaan operasional, infrastruktur digital, dan regenerasi relawan. Artikel ini menegaskan bahwa manajemen TBM berbasis aktivitas merupakan model yang menjanjikan untuk mengintegrasikan literasi, pengembangan keterampilan, dan pemberdayaan masyarakat pedesaan.

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INTRODUCTION

Literacy remains a central issue in rural community development because limited access to information, educational resources, and functional skills can reduce people's capacity to participate in social and economic life (Addae, 2021; Bai & Yang, 2025; Grotlüschen et al., 2025; He et al., 2025). In many rural areas, empowerment cannot be reduced to income improvement alone; it also requires learning spaces that help community members read, discuss, collaborate, preserve local culture, and transform knowledge into productive skills (Affandi et al., 2025; Christmann et al., 2024; Harinurdin et al., 2025; Sambodo et al., 2023; Thomson et al., 2024). Community Reading Parks, known in Indonesia as Taman Bacaan Masyarakat (TBM), are therefore important nonformal education institutions because they can bridge literacy services, lifelong learning, and community-based empowerment (Afrina et al., 2023; Ardana & Mulyono, 2025; Atmasari et al., 2024; Setyaningsih & Kharismawati, 2020).

TBM Gubug Pintar as a community learning space in Kapanewon Semanu, Gunungkidul Regency. The area faces literacy, welfare, and access challenges, while the local community has social capital, cultural assets, and local products that can be strengthened through organized community learning. TBM Gubug Pintar has developed from a reading space into an activity-based empowerment center that accommodates children, parents, youth groups, women's groups, volunteers, and local stakeholders. Its programs include reading activities, writing classes, Qur'anic learning, entrepreneurship training, traditional food festivals, arts and cultural preservation, digital literacy, and environmental activities.

Previous studies on TBM and nonformal education emphasize that community-based learning institutions can strengthen literacy habits, support vulnerable groups, and create inclusive public spaces (Fauzi & Nurhayati, 2025; Novrita et al., 2025; Nur et al., 2024). However, many TBM programs remain dependent on voluntary enthusiasm and short-term external support (Atmasari et al., 2024; Fauzi & Nurhayati, 2025; Prahestiwi et al., 2021; Siregar et al., 2024). The research gap addressed in this article is the need to explain how TBM management functions are translated into concrete empowerment activities and how those activities produce educational, social, economic, and cultural outcomes. Accordingly, this article aims to analyze the management strategy of TBM Gubug Pintar, describe the results of its activity-based empowerment programs, and identify the factors that support and hinder program sustainability.

METHOD

This study used a descriptive qualitative design because the research focused on understanding management practices, program implementation, community participation, and empowerment outcomes in their natural setting. The research site was TBM Gubug Pintar in Semanu, Gunungkidul Regency, Yogyakarta Special Region, Indonesia. The qualitative design was appropriate for exploring how managers, volunteers, participants, and community stakeholders interpreted the role of TBM in community empowerment.

The information sources consisted of the main TBM manager, volunteers, activity participants, parents, youth or community group members, community leaders, and local government representatives. Data were collected through in-depth interviews, participant observation, and documentation. The interview data captured planning, organizing, implementation, evaluation, perceived outcomes, supporting factors, and obstacles. Observation focused on program activities, participation patterns, use of facilities, and community interactions. Documentation included annual work plans, activity reports, photos, posters, and records of facilities and membership.

Data validity was strengthened through source triangulation and method triangulation. The analysis followed an interactive qualitative procedure consisting of data collection, data condensation, data display, and conclusion drawing. The findings were then synthesized into a journal-article format using thematic categories: management strategy, activity-based empowerment programs, program outcomes, supporting factors, inhibiting factors, and implications for sustainable nonformal education.

Table 1. Information sources and data focus

No.	Informant category	Main information explored
1	TBM manager	Planning, organizing, implementation, evaluation, partnerships, and institutional sustainability
2	Volunteers	Roles in program delivery, facilitation methods, challenges, and community engagement
3	Activity participants and parents	Benefits of literacy, skills, cultural, religious, and economic programs
4	Community leaders	Community perception, social participation, cultural relevance, and local support
5	Local government representatives	Policy support, facilitation, collaboration, and development synergy

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

TBM Gubug Pintar is not only a reading facility but also a community learning hub built on local values. The word gubug refers to a simple rural gathering place where villagers, especially farmers, share stories, rest, and discuss daily problems. This symbolic meaning is important because the TBM is designed as an accessible social space that combines reading, discussion, play, training, cultural activities, and community meetings. The facility includes a reading room, a pendopo, a terrace, and a small post, supported by book collections and several learning facilities.

Table 2. Selected facilities at TBM Gubug Pintar

No.	Facility	Quantity	Function in community learning
1	Bookshelves	3	Storage and display of reading materials
2	Chairs	10	Seating for reading, meetings, and training
3	Small folding tables	14	Flexible use for classes, writing, and group activities
4	Computers	10	Digital literacy, learning support, and content production
5	Printer	1	Administrative support and learning material preparation
6	Whiteboard	1	Teaching, discussion, and planning support
7	Wall clock	1	Time management during scheduled activities

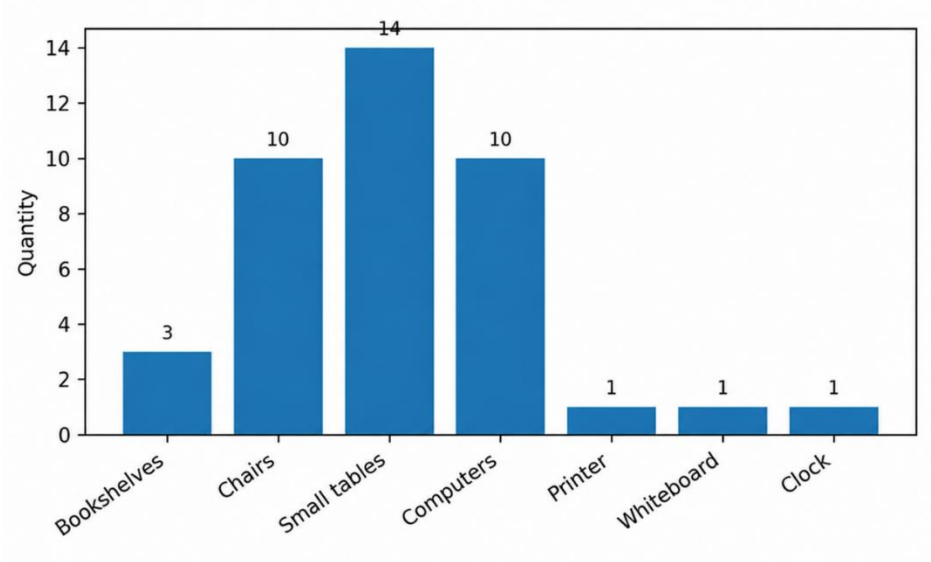


Figure 1. Selected facilities supporting literacy and empowerment activities at TBM Gubug Pintar.

The membership data show that the TBM serves multiple community groups. Students constitute the largest proportion of active members, followed by housewives, youth group members, and elementary school teachers. This composition confirms that the TBM is intergenerational. It supports children's reading and learning while also opening access for women, youth, and teachers to participate in broader community empowerment programs.

Table 3. Active members of TBM Gubug Pintar in March 2025

No.	Member category	Number	Percentage
1	Students from elementary to senior high school	25	47.2%
2	Housewives	12	22.6%
3	Youth organization members	10	18.9%
4	Elementary school teachers	6	11.3%
Total		53	100%

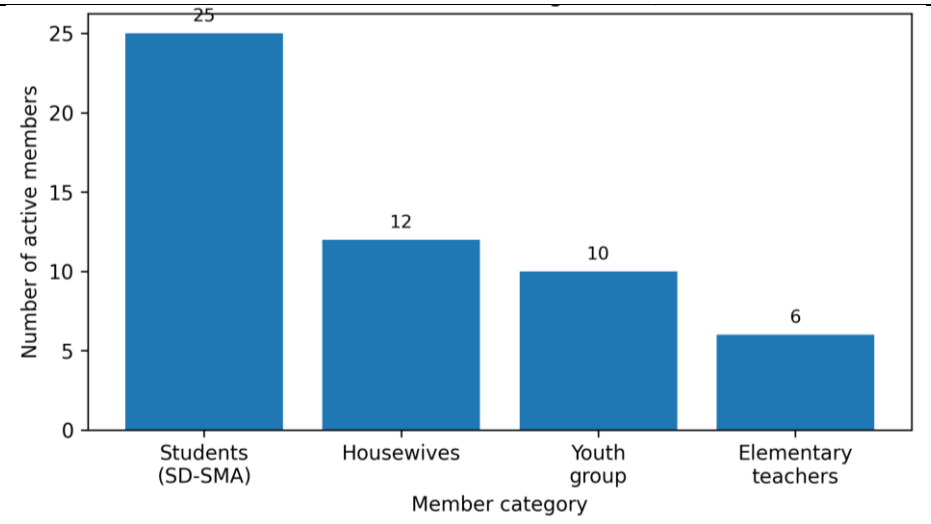


Figure 2. Distribution of active members by category in March 2025.

The management strategy of TBM Gubug Pintar is best understood as an activity-based cycle. Planning begins with identifying community needs and mapping local potentials. Organizing is conducted through the distribution of roles among managers, volunteers, community groups, and partners. Actuating refers to the implementation of literacy, skills, religious, cultural, environmental, and economic activities. Controlling is carried out through reflective meetings, community feedback, activity documentation, and program adjustment. This cycle links the classical management functions with participatory community empowerment.

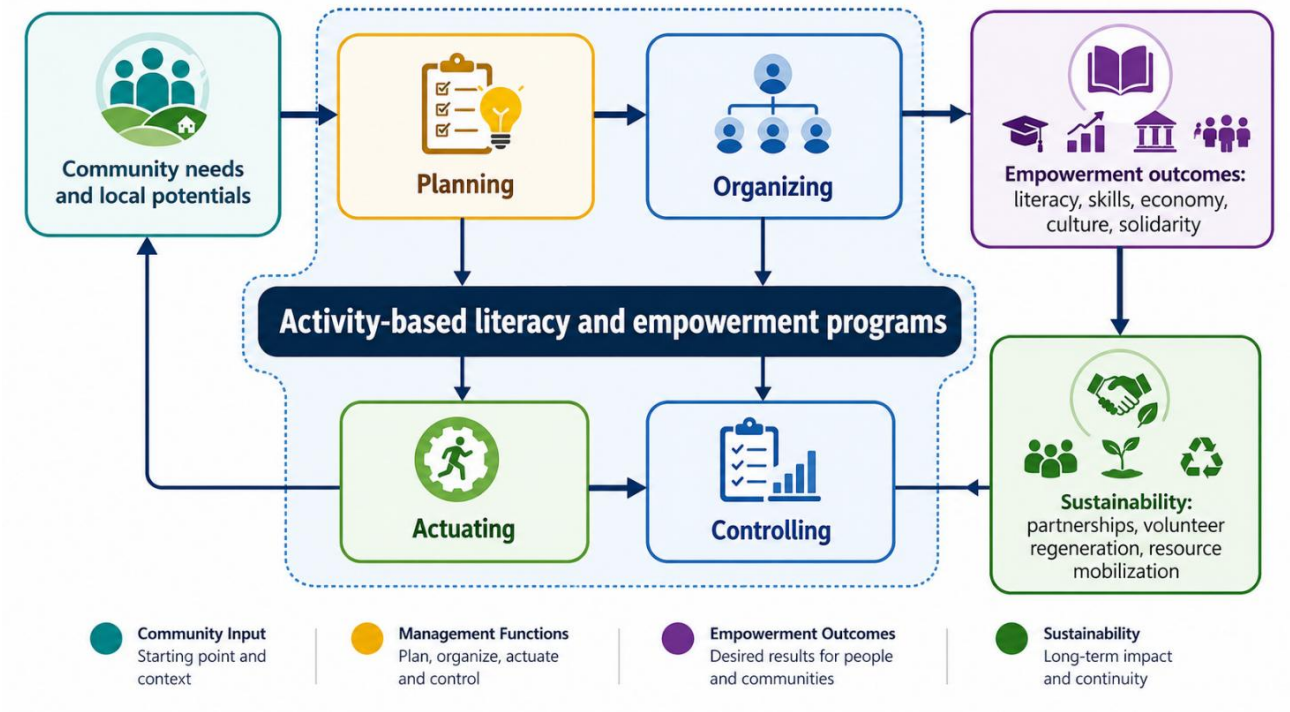


Figure 3. Activity-based management model for TBM Gubug Pintar.

Table 4. Activity-based management strategy and empowerment direction

Management stage	Key process	Representative TBM programs	Empowerment direction
Planning	Identifying needs, mapping local potentials, and preparing annual themes	Sinau Bareng, children-parent creativity events, entrepreneurship training, cultural preservation, environmental literacy	Educational empowerment through stronger literacy awareness and community learning participation
Organizing	Assigning roles, coordinating volunteers, and involving partners	Volunteer facilitation, community committees, collaboration with schools, PKK, Dasawisma, KUBE, local government, and communities	Social and cultural empowerment through shared responsibility and collective ownership
Actuating	Implementing participatory literacy, skills, cultural, digital, and environmental activities	Reading and writing classes, Qur'anic learning, traditional food festivals, product training, digital promotion, arts practice, green literacy	Skills and economic empowerment through productive competence and local creativity
Controlling	Conducting reflection, documenting activities, identifying constraints, and planning follow-up	Evaluation meetings, annual program renewal, replication of effective activities, partnership strengthening	Institutional sustainability through adaptive programming and community accountability

The results of the strategy can be grouped into four major outcomes. First, the TBM strengthens basic and functional literacy. Reading classes, writing activities, Sinau Bareng, storytelling, and creative competitions make literacy more attractive to children and families. Second, the TBM expands productive skills through training in local food processing, handicrafts, sewing, agricultural products, digital promotion, and family finance. Third, the TBM preserves local culture through traditional food festivals, gejog lesung, karawitan, dance, and community performances. Fourth, the TBM strengthens social solidarity because the activities depend on voluntary participation, mutual assistance, and cross-group collaboration.

Table 5. Main empowerment programs and observed outcomes

Program cluster	Examples of activities	Main participants	Observed outcomes
Basic literacy and children's learning	Sinau Bareng, reading class, writing class, TPA, Iqra' class	Children, parents, volunteers, religious teachers	Improved reading habits, writing practice, learning confidence, and parent involvement
Family and community creativity	Children-parent creativity events, coloring, storytelling, poetry, and games	Children, parents, schools, volunteers	Higher family participation and more attractive literacy experiences
Women and community groups	PKK, Dasawisma, KUBE meetings, discussions, and training	Women's groups, community members, TBM managers	Stronger social networks and women's participation in community programs
Local economy and entrepreneurship	Food processing, handicrafts, local product development, digital marketing	Housewives, youth, UMKM actors, volunteers	New productive skills and opportunities to sell community products
Arts and cultural preservation	Traditional food festival, gejog lesung, karawitan, traditional dance	Children, youth, artists, community groups	Cultural continuity, youth involvement, and community identity strengthening
Environmental and green literacy	Vegetable planting, clean and green activities, green bazaar	Children, families, volunteers, community groups	Environmental awareness and practical community action



Figure 4. Community-based activity at TBM G ubug Pintar documented during the field study.

Several enabling factors support this model. The first is volunteer commitment. Volunteers act as facilitators, mentors, organizers, and communicators between the TBM and the community. The second is community participation, which is reflected in the willingness of residents to provide space, food, ideas, and direct involvement in activities. The third is government and institutional support, including books, training, facilitation, and recognition. The fourth is multisector partnership, particularly with schools, community organizations, local leaders, and external communities. These factors allow the TBM to maintain activities even when formal resources are limited (Farhan et al., 2022; Lestari et al., 2024; Sánchez et al., 2025).

The inhibiting factors are also significant. Limited operational funding makes it difficult to plan long-term programs, renew book collections, maintain facilities, and provide incentives for volunteers. Facility constraints influence the comfort and scale of activities, especially when many children or community members attend. Digital literacy programs are constrained by internet access, devices, and the capacity of managers to maintain digital services. Another important issue is volunteer regeneration. Without younger volunteers and systematic capacity building, the sustainability of activity-based management may weaken over time.

The discussion suggests that TBM Gubug Pintar offers a practical model of nonformal education that integrates literacy, skills, culture, and community development. Its novelty lies in the way management functions are not treated as administrative routines but are embedded in participatory activities. Planning is community-based, organizing is volunteer-driven, implementation is locally contextualized, and evaluation is reflective. This model is relevant for rural TBM development because it shows how reading spaces can become empowerment spaces when literacy is connected to livelihood skills, cultural assets, family learning, and social solidarity.

CONCLUSION

The activity-based management strategy of TBM Gubug Pintar demonstrates how a community reading park can function as a rural empowerment institution. The strategy integrates planning, organizing, actuating, and controlling through participatory programs based on local needs and potentials. The outcomes include stronger literacy practices, family economic creativity, preservation of local culture, environmental awareness, and social solidarity. The main supporting factors are volunteer commitment, community participation, government support, and partnerships, while the major constraints include limited facilities, funding, digital infrastructure, and volunteer regeneration. Follow-up development should focus on strengthening resource mobilization, systematic volunteer training, digital service capacity, and impact documentation so that TBM Gubug Pintar can become a replicable model for community-based literacy and empowerment.

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